



LIGHTNING GOES LIVE

048 / 15 MAR 2018 / BITCOIN / UNCOMMON

THE VERY BEGINNING.

On 15 March 2018, Lightning Labs released Ind 0.4-beta, its first mainnet beta. The software now offered an option to run on Bitcoin's live network with real funds. This card marks that release milestone; Lightning's proposal and earlier experiments already existed.

Lightning begins with funded payment channels. An opening transaction commits bitcoin on the blockchain. The two participants can then update their balances between themselves, making repeated payments without recording every update on-chain. Closing a channel settles its balance on the blockchain, which remains the foundation for enforcing the arrangement.

A payment can also travel through linked channels to someone beyond a direct partner. Conditional transfers connect the steps, while onion routing limits what each forwarding node learns about the route. Available channel funds and routing fees still matter. The aim is faster, lower-cost payments, not unlimited or free transfers.

The beta was aimed at application developers, technical users and prospective routing-node operators. It brought stronger fault handling and improved route finding, but Lightning Labs urged people to experiment with small amounts. The announcement looked ahead to friendlier applications and more infrastructure: this was an early network still being built.

HISTROVE turns that moment into a storm-to-Earth allegory. An invented guardian channels golden light toward a web of connections below; paired Bitcoin clasps, a release plaque and a date tag carry the historical clues. The figure represents no real person or central controller, and the scene is not an engineering demonstration.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE BETA PLAQUE

The chest plaque reads Ind 0.4-beta. It identifies the specific software release, anchoring the scene to Lightning Labs' first mainnet beta rather than the invention of Lightning itself.

02 THE HANGING DATE

The tag reads 15 MAR 2018, the release announcement's date. It records this milestone, not the date of the first Lightning idea or the first payment ever made.

03 THE BITCOIN CLASPS

Two Bitcoin clasp halves are joined by light. They suggest the two participants in a funded channel, whose balances can change off-chain while their channel remains anchored to Bitcoin's blockchain.

04 THE SPHINX BRACER

The engraved Sphinx nods to the Sphinx-derived packet format used for Lightning onion routing. Layered instructions guide a payment through its route. The mythical engraving is an artistic clue, not actual networking equipment.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: Lightning Labs: mainnet beta announcement; Ind v0.4-beta release notes; Poon and Dryja: Lightning whitepaper; lightning-onion: historical Sphinx design; Ind v0.4-beta: dependency record. The guardian and storm-to-Earth scene are allegory, not a real person or technical demonstration. THE VERY BEGINNING. uses continuous words from the announcement's Beyond Beta opening, with capitals and a final full stop added for the card.